

Getting to 100:

Fixing Your Anthology Ally Errors



Damian Sian

Adjunct professor

School of Communication and
Information, Library Sciences

Rutgers University – New Brunswick

RUTGERS ONLINE LEARNING CONFERENCE 2026



RUTGERS UNIVERSITY
Office of University Online
Education Services

Agenda

Background and housekeeping

1. Presenter introduction
2. Workshop structure
3. Scope of the challenge and technology limitations

Hands-on activities

1. Text alternatives
2. Color
3. Structure (headings and tables)
4. Links
5. Video captions
6. Flashing blinking



Section one: Presenter introduction

Who the hell does this guy think he is anyway?

RUTGERS
ONLINE LEARNING
CONFERENCE
2026

R | RUTGERS UNIVERSITY
Office of University Online
Education Services

<

#

Covered in section one

Meet your workshop facilitator, Damian Sian and learn about his:

1. Work history
2. Credentials
3. Background in accessibility
4. Important highlights in the field of accessibility

Work history

- Damian has worked in the accessibility field for 14 years for institutions such as Princeton University and Prudential Financial.
- He teaches an *Introduction to Web Accessibility* course at Rutgers University on the New Brunswick campus.
- Damian currently serves as a Principal Engineering Program Manager at Adobe on the Product Equity team.



Credentials

Damian has just about all the accessibility credentials one can obtain from the International Association of Accessibility Professionals (IAAP).

- Certified Practitioner of Accessibility Core Competencies (CPACC)
- Web Accessibility Specialist (WAS)
- Certified Practitioner of Web Accessibility (CPWA)
- Accessible Document Specialist (ADS)



Working on a UX Design accessibility certification IAAP and curriculum with TeachAccess.

Background in accessibility

- Front-end development (HTML and mostly React)
- Document accessibility (30 years in communications industry)
- Automated and manual testing (including building tools and process)
- Triage and remediation with globally distributed teams
- Assistive technologies (screen reader and voice control)
- Compliance, governance, and resource for legal
- Process and policy creation and enforcement
- Enablement and training (corporate adult learning)
- Curriculum and certification development



Two important highlights

Speaking at the United Nations was pretty cool.



But my recycling bins are by far my proudest achievement.



Section two: Workshop structure

How we'll facilitate our interactive this interactive journey.

RUTGERS
ONLINE LEARNING
CONFERENCE
2026

R | RUTGERS UNIVERSITY
Office of University Online
Education Services

<

#

Covered in section two

This is how we'll work together today.

1. Where to find your sample files
2. Following along in Canvas LMS Ally tool
3. The website resource
4. Room for questions/challenges



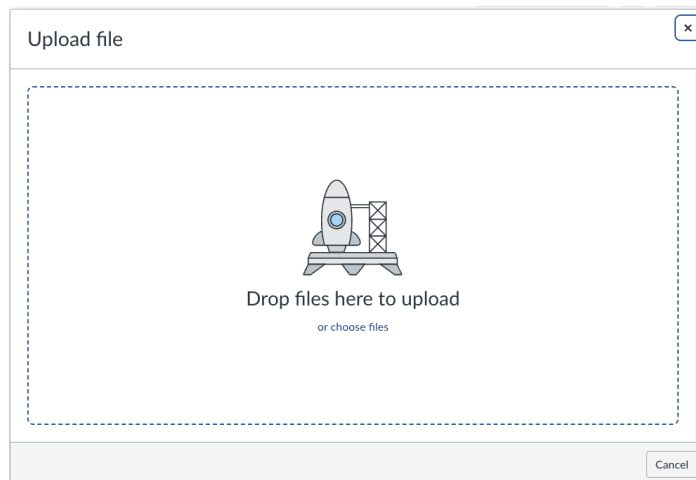
Sample files

- Download the zip package here, or go the website and download the samples there, your choice.
- Wherever possible, a file is provided for you to place into the Canvas LMS.
- We will trigger automated errors and learn how to resolve them.
- We will also expose where automated testing is lacking.
- Damian will demonstrate assistive technology throughout.
- You are not required to use assistive technology to follow along.
- You will need MS Word, MS PowerPoint, and Acrobat Professional if you intend to follow along with all the topics today.
- You will need access to an instance of Canvas if you intend to follow along (a test course would be the best if you have one).



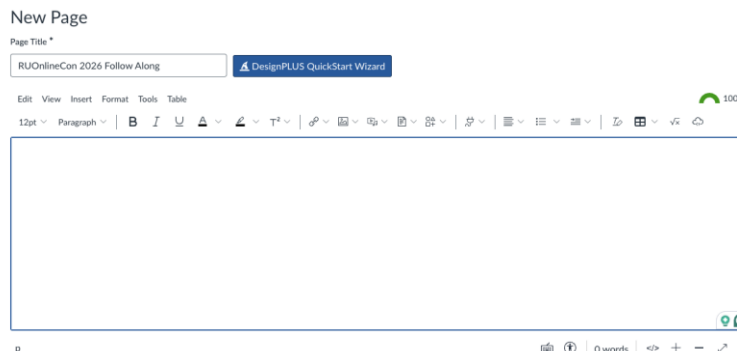
Following along Canvas

File upload function



You're encouraged to create a folder in your files section of Canvas, so you don't muddy your existing file structure in your course.

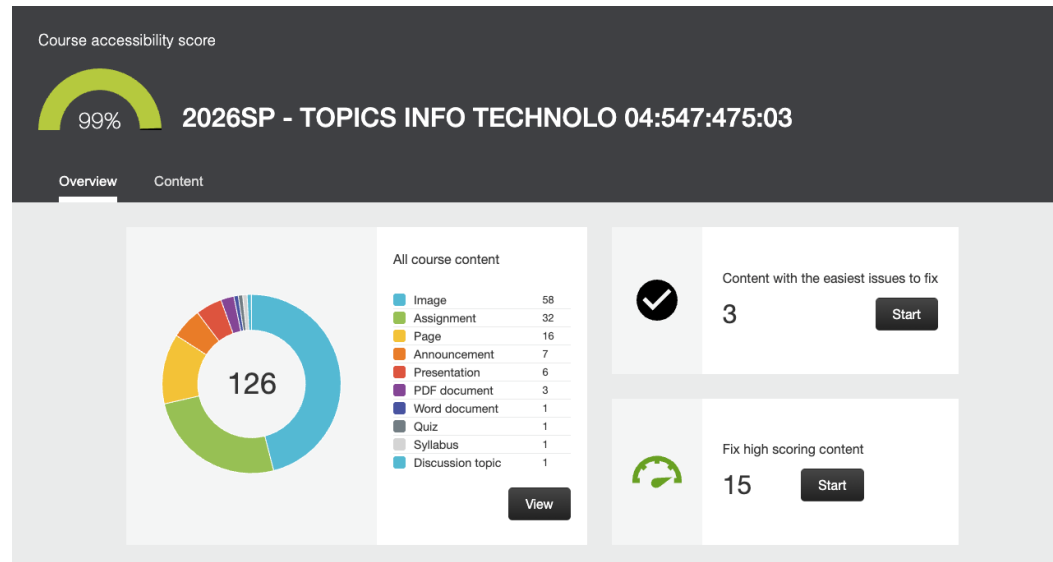
Rich Content Editor (RCE)



You're encouraged to create a new Page in your Canvas instance where we can play and make a mess.

Accessibility dashboard

We will be looking at the course accessibility score and dashboard in Canvas as well.



Website reference resource

In addition to this deck, a website is available to you that is a 1:1 match of the content in this workshop complete with:

1. The sample files
2. Explanations of the tests
3. Shortcomings of Ally
4. Impact on students with disabilities
5. Example outputs from screen readers
6. Step-by-step guides on how to fix issues as shown here today

Home / Text Alternatives

Text Alternatives

Overview

Overview Word PowerPoint PDF Canvas editor Image

Overview

Images, graphics, and non-text content need text descriptions so screen readers can convey meaning to students who cannot see them. This is the most common Ally error across all file types: every image needs alternative text that describes its meaning in context.

This category covers WCAG 1.1.1 (Non-text Content, Level A). Ally checks for alt text in **Word**, **PowerPoint**, **PDF**, **Canvas**, and **Image** files. The pages in this section walk through each file type with specific instructions, screenshots, and testing results.

Text alternatives is the highest-impact, highest-likelihood category. If you fix one thing across your courses, this should be it.

Ally Error Messages

Ally reports slightly different error messages depending on the file type, but the underlying issue is always the same: an image is missing alt text.

ALLY ERROR MESSAGE

"Document has images without alt descriptions"

Severity: **Major** - WCAG 1.1.1 Non-text Content (Level A)

Word	"Document has images without alt descriptions"
PowerPoint	"Presentation has images without alt descriptions"
PDF	"PDF has images without alternative descriptions"
Canvas	"Images must have alternate text description"
Image	"Image does not have alternative description"

ON THIS PAGE

- Overview
- Ally Error Messages
- Hear the Difference
- Results by File Type
- Checker Detection: Images (example)
- False Positive
- What Ally Catches
- What Ally Misses
- Quick Reference
- Resources

DRAFT – Getting help in real-time

- Hopefully, someone can monitor the chat.
- You have deck and the website resource as well.



Section three: Scope of the challenge

The scope and limitations of automated testing.

RUTGERS
ONLINE LEARNING
CONFERENCE
2026

R | RUTGERS UNIVERSITY
Office of University Online
Education Services

<

#

Covered in section three

To come.

1. What is Ally actually testing?
2. What is it missing?
3. What is it getting wrong (false positives)?
4. Tractability



What is Ally actually testing?

Content type	Number of tests
Rich content editor	54
Image files	4
PDF documents	14
Word documents	11
PowerPoint presentations	8
Total	91

Source: [Anthology help accessibility checklist](#)

What's missing – alt text use case

Type of test	Ally	MS Office	Acrobat
No text alternative	✓	✓	✓
AI-generated text alternative	X	✓	X
Should be decorative (divider line)	X	X	X
Vague alt text (2026 sales chart)	X	X	X
Dense alt text (>120 char)	False positive	n/a	n/a
File name as alt text (logo.png)	✓	✓	X
Gibberish (alskjshdsflh)	X	X	X
Placeholder (image)	X	X	X

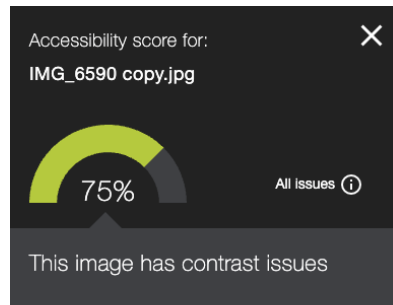
False positives

Image contrast

- Contrast checks require information like font size and usage (i.e., text or graphic).
- There may be ways to determine those factors, but the tool is NOT doing that today.
- This feature is entirely unreliable and these results can largely be ignored.

Text contrast PowerPoint files

- Ally is rendering the PPTX files and in that rendering its misinterpreting colors and some text gets wrapped.



Guidance not available yet

We are updating the guidance for this issue.



Where they exceed expectation

- Links



Tractability



Section three: Text alternatives

High likelihood of occurrence, high impact for non-conformance.

RUTGERS
ONLINE LEARNING
CONFERENCE
2026

R | RUTGERS UNIVERSITY
Office of University Online
Education Services

<

#

Covered in section four

To come.

1. Overview
2. Impact to students with disabilities
3. Forcing errors in Ally (using sample files)
4. Fixing issues (fixing sample files)



Overview

Concept

- Images, graphics, and non-text content need text descriptions so screen readers can convey meaning to students who cannot see them.

Severity and likelihood

- High likelihood
- High severity

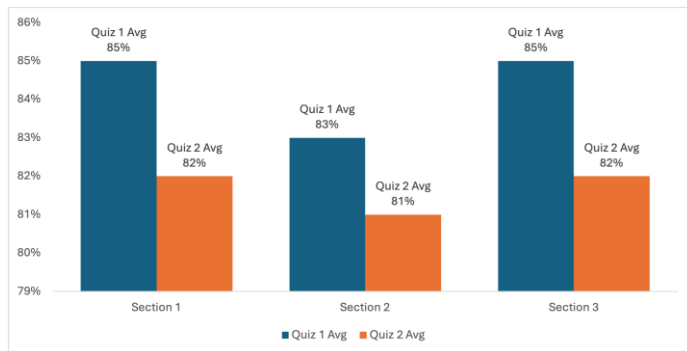
What content gets tested?

- Word documents
- PowerPoint presentations
- PDF documents
- Canvas Rich Content Editor (RCE)
- Image uploads

Associated WCAG

- [SC 1.1.1:Non-text Content \(Level A\)](#)

Student impact – alt text



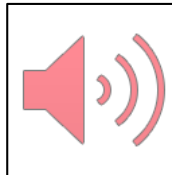
Alt text should be

“Grouped bar graph comparing Quiz 1 and Quiz 2 averages across three sections. Section 1: 85% and 82%. Section 2: 83% and 81%. Section 3: 85% and 82%.”



With no alt text

What’s happening – the screen reader reads the file name as there was no text alternative provided.



With good alt text

What’s happening – the screen reader provides full context to the image’s purpose and meaning.

Forcing errors

Type of test	Ally	MS Office	Acrobat
No text alternative	✓	✓	✓
AI-generated text alternative	X	✓	X
Should be decorative (divider line)	X	X	X
Vague alt text (2026 sales chart)	X	X	X
Dense alt text (>120 char)	False positive	n/a	n/a
File name as alt text (logo.png)	✓	✓	X
Gibberish (alskjshdsflh)	X	X	X
Placeholder (image)	X	X	X

Alt text samples to Canvas Files

- Move the alt text samples over to Canvas.
- System analyzes files on the fly.
- Results show inline next to files, and in the Accessibility Dashboard.
- Hover over an icon to see score.

☐	Name ▾	Created ▴	Last Modified ▴	Modified By ▴	Size ▴	Accessibility	Status	Actions
☐	 Chart-good-alt.png	2:46pm	2:46pm	DAMIAN SIAN	167 KB			
☐	 Image-PDF.pdf	2:29pm	2:45pm	DAMIAN SIAN	310 KB			
☐	 Image-PowerPoint.pptx	2:34pm	2:34pm	DAMIAN SIAN	388 KB			
☐	 Image-Word.docx	2:29pm	2:29pm	DAMIAN SIAN	278 KB			

Fix image upload alt text

- Fix from either dashboard or Files.
- Select the red dashboard icon pointing to low 25%.

Course accessibility score

98%

2026SP - TOPICS INFO TECHNOLO 04:547:475:03

[← Back to overview](#)

Name	Issues	↑ Score
 Chart-good-alt.png Image	1	 25%

[Previous](#) [1](#) [Next](#)



The image does not have a description

1 out of 129

Accessibility	Status	Actions
		

Adding images in Canvas editor

- The system will allow you to upload images without alt text unfortunately.
- The system will default to using the file name of the image as its alt text.
- This will show up on your Accessibility Dashboard impacting your overall score.

Accessibility Checker ×

Issue 2/2



Image filenames should not be used as the alt attribute describing the image content.

Change alt text

Chart-good-alt-2.png

☐ Decorative image

Prev

Next

Apply

False positive dense alt text

- In the Rich Content Editor, Ally will incorrectly state that “Alt attribute text should not contain more than 120 characters.”
- This is false and has been noted to Anthology.
- This false positive will not appear on your Accessibility Dashboard, only in the editor screen.

Accessibility Checker

Issue 1/1



Alt attribute text should not contain more than 120 characters.

Change alt text

Grouped bar graph comparing Quiz 1 and Quiz 2 averages across three sections. Section 1: 85% and 82%. Section 2: 83% and 81%. Section 3: 85% and 82%.

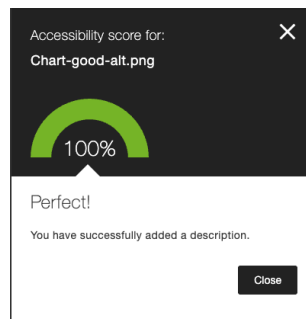
Prev

Next

Apply

Fix image upload alt text – continued

- Use this text:
 - Grouped bar graph comparing Quiz 1 and Quiz 2 averages across three sections. Section 1: 85% and 82%. Section 2: 83% and 81%. Section 3: 85% and 82%.
- Select Add.
- Issue is resolved.
- Using auto-generate is a good first step, but any text alternative must be human generated or human reviewed/edited.
- This image cannot be marked decorative.



Size	Accessibility score: Perfect	Status
167 KB		

Accessibility score for:
Chart-good-alt.png

25%

This image is missing a description

What this means

How to write a good description

Add image description

Grouped bar graph comparing Quiz 1 and Quiz 2 averages across three sections. Section 1: 85% and 82%. Section 2: 83% and 81%. Section 3: 85% and 82%.

Add

Auto-generate description

Or ☐ Indicate image is decorative

This image is used for decoration only and a description is not needed

Fix alt text in PDF

- Review issue from Files interface or the Accessibility Dashboard.
- To fix issue, we will use Acrobat Pro.

Example error: Images in PDF

No text alternative

1 / 2 No alt text for this image.



	A11y automated checker	Acrobat accessibility checker
Result	Detected	Detected

AI-generated text alternative

MS Word guessed the text alternative as "A black background with white text. AI-generated content may be incorrect."



	A11y automated checker	Acrobat accessibility checker
Result	Not Detected	Not Detected

Should be decorative

This decorative non-text content should be marked decorative, but it has a text alternative instead.

Accessibility score for: Image-PDF.pdf

87%

This PDF contains images without description

[What this means](#)

[How to add descriptions](#)

Upload a version with image descriptions

Drop file to upload or [Browse](#)

[Help](#)

Document uploads alt text detection

- Same detection will be made in Word, PowerPoint, and PDF documents.
- To fix the issues, we'll need to fix in the documents, and re-upload them.